

Questions to Ask Before Spending on Google Ads

A plain-English way to decide whether paid search fits the business, what needs to be ready first, and what a sensible test could look like.

Understand the situation first.

Use evidence, not assumptions, to decide what to do next.

This guide is intentionally neutral: it explains the tradeoffs instead of assuming Google Ads is the answer.

Before you put money behind the click

There is a moment almost every business reaches: someone says, "We should try Google Ads." That may turn out to be a smart move. It may not. The more useful question is what the business already knows, what it can measure, and what it is prepared to learn from paid traffic.

This guide is meant to help with that conversation. It does not assume you should run Google Ads, and it does not assume you should not. Instead, it lays out the questions that make the decision easier to reason about.

1. Start with the customer, not the platform

Google Ads is a distribution system. It can put an offer in front of people who are searching, but it does not create a compelling offer, fix a weak sales process, or make an unclear website persuasive. Before talking about campaigns, be clear about what the customer is actually looking for.

- What problem is the customer already trying to solve?
- Is there a recognizable search behavior around that problem, product, or service?
- What would make someone choose this business over an alternative?
- What does the buyer need to believe before taking the next step?
- Is the offer available where and when the customer wants it?

2. What Google Ads can actually do

Google Ads can place ads in Google advertising inventory, including Search and other campaign types. In Search, keywords and other targeting signals can make an ad eligible for a query. Google can then optimize delivery toward the goals selected for the campaign. What it cannot do by itself is guarantee demand, profitability, quality leads, or a sale. Those depend on the offer, audience, competition, auction conditions, landing page, sales process, and measurement.

Google Ads can help with	Google Ads does not automatically solve
Reach people showing relevant search intent	Weak positioning or an unclear offer
Test messages and offers quickly	Poor landing-page relevance or usability
Generate measurable traffic and conversion data	A slow sales follow-up process
Scale a working acquisition path	Bad unit economics
Compare queries, ads, audiences, and landing pages	An offer people do not want

3. The business case: what would a useful test look like?

A good test has a clear question. "Let us spend \$500 and see what happens" is a budget decision, but it is not yet a learning plan. A better setup says what the campaign is intended to prove, which outcome will count, what will be watched, and what decision follows from the result.

- Define the primary outcome: purchase, qualified lead, booked appointment, call, or another business event.
- Set a test period long enough to gather meaningful evidence without forcing a premature conclusion.
- Define the maximum acceptable cost for the desired outcome using actual business economics.
- Decide what would cause you to change the message, targeting, landing page, offer, or measurement.

- Decide what would cause you to stop rather than keep spending because "the algorithm needs more time."

4. Understand the economics before you buy traffic

The important number is usually not the cost of a click. It is what a useful customer is worth after the costs of acquiring and serving that customer. A campaign can produce cheap clicks and still be economically poor. It can also have expensive clicks and still make sense if the resulting customers are valuable and the conversion path is strong.

Metric	Question to answer
Average order value / revenue per visit	What is the normal value of a new customer or transaction?
Gross margin or contribution margin	How much of that revenue can actually support acquisition?
Lead-to-customer rate	What share of leads become paying customers?
Maximum acceptable CAC	What can the business afford to spend to acquire a customer?
Expected conversion rate	What portion of qualified visitors are likely to take the desired action?
Lead response time	How quickly does someone follow up after a lead arrives?

Example only: if a business closes 20% of qualified leads and can afford \$400 to acquire a customer, the implied maximum lead acquisition cost is about \$80. That is a planning calculation, not a Google Ads benchmark. The actual limit should come from the business own economics.

5. Is search demand actually present?

Paid search works best when the market gives you enough people expressing relevant intent. Research the language customers use, the questions they ask, the locations they include, and the alternatives they search for. Do not assume that a product being valuable means there will be enough search volume to support a useful campaign.

- List the top customer problems and the words customers actually use.
- Separate buying intent from research, support, jobs, definitions, free resources, and unrelated meanings.
- Look at competitor presence as context, not proof that their campaign is profitable.
- Identify local qualifiers, service-area terms, product models, brands, or other high-intent modifiers.
- Estimate whether the market is large enough for the desired acquisition volume.

6. Can the website handle paid traffic?

Google describes landing-page experience partly in terms of usefulness, relevance, navigation, and whether the page meets the expectations created by the ad. A strong paid-search setup is therefore a conversation between the query, ad, and destination-not three separate pieces.

- The landing page matches the search intent.
- The main benefit and next action are obvious quickly.
- Trust information is easy to find.
- Forms, calls, purchases, or bookings work on mobile.
- Page speed is reasonable and the page does not depend on fragile scripts to display the core offer.

- The destination does not force unnecessary steps before the customer can act.

7. What about tracking?

Google Ads can optimize against conversion actions, so measurement is not merely a reporting task. Google currently distinguishes primary conversion actions, which can be used in the Conversions column and for bidding when selected, from secondary actions that are generally observed rather than used for standard bidding.

- Can you tell the difference between a visitor, a lead, a qualified lead, and a customer?
- Which actions should influence bidding, and which should only be observed?
- Can the business test the tracking path from ad click through the actual business outcome?
- Are imported analytics events configured intentionally rather than copied into Ads without review?
- Will the team trust the numbers enough to make budget decisions?

8. What are the real tradeoffs?

Potential benefit	Potential tradeoff / limitation
Fast feedback	Fast feedback can tempt teams to change too many variables at once.
Measurable traffic	Measurement can look precise while tracking the wrong business action.
Ability to target search intent	The auction is competitive, and costs vary by market and query.
Flexible testing	More options create more opportunities for poor structure or unclear goals.
Automation and Smart Bidding	Automation still depends on the quality and quantity of the signals it receives.
Reach beyond existing brand demand	Paid traffic stops when the spend stops.

9. Questions to ask before you spend

- What exactly are we trying to get from paid search?
- What evidence says customers are searching for this?
- What search terms should we avoid?
- What will the customer see after the click?
- What makes the offer credible?
- What conversion actually matters to the business?
- How will we know if the conversion tracking is correct?
- What is a financially acceptable acquisition cost?
- Who will answer leads or fulfill orders?
- What would make us stop, pause, or change the experiment?

10. Read the numbers without overreacting

Use the early data to answer specific questions. A low click-through rate can point to a relevance or message problem; a healthy click rate with weak conversions can shift attention to the landing page, offer, or audience; a healthy lead count with poor close rates can move the problem downstream into sales. The useful response is diagnosis, not a reflexive increase in spend.

One practical discipline: change one meaningful variable at a time when the goal is learning. Otherwise, it becomes difficult to tell what actually caused the change.

11. A reasonable decision can be "not yet"

Sometimes the information points toward testing Google Ads. Sometimes it points toward fixing the offer, improving the landing page, clarifying the target audience, establishing measurement, or building a sales follow-up process first. "Not yet" is a useful business decision when it is tied to a specific missing condition and a plan to revisit it.

The goal is not to become good at running ads for their own sake. The goal is to know whether paid search has a reasonable place in the way this business acquires customers-and to understand what the business would need to learn before committing more money.

Sources and current-version note

Google Ads changes over time. Interface labels, campaign availability, recommendations, and policy enforcement can change. This resource uses Google documentation available during September 2026 and is written so that the reader can verify the current settings in the account before launch.

About keyword matching options

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/7478529>

About primary and secondary conversion actions

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/11461796>

Landing page

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/14086>

Evaluate the performance of your landing pages

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/7543502>

About conversion measurement

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/1722022>

About responsive search ads

<https://support.google.com/google-ads/answer/7684791>